PYTHON AND AI · EPISODE 03

How to Install Python

Getting Started

KEY POINTS

- "Install Python" really means: install the **Python interpreter**.
- Always download it from **python.org**. Latest version: **Python 3.15.2**.
- **Windows:** install the **Python install manager**, then type `python` in a terminal.
- **Mac:** run the macOS installer, then use `python3`. Check with `python --version`.

01 The Interpreter

▶ VIDEO 00:22

A computer only runs machine code: ones and zeros. You write Python, words like `print`, `if` and `else`. The **interpreter** sits in the middle: it reads your code line by line and gets the computer to carry it out.

FIGURE 3.1 **From your code to the computer**



When people say "install Python," they mean: install the interpreter.

hello_if.py — PYTHON

```python
# Episode 03 · Python words a computer can't read on its own: the interpreter runs them.
ready = True
if ready:
    print("Hello")
else:
    print("Wait")
```

02 python.org

▶ VIDEO 00:56

Python's official home is **python.org**, run by the Python Software Foundation. Click **Downloads**: the site detects your system and offers the right download. As of November 2026 the latest version is **Python 3.15.2**; Python 3.15 came out in October 2026.

03 Windows

▶ VIDEO 01:23

- The download button says **Download Python install manager**. That's the official way on Windows; the old standalone installer won't be made for Python 3.16 or later. The Microsoft Store version is identical.
- Open the downloaded file and click **Install**. Then open **Terminal** and type `python`: the install manager downloads Python 3.15.2 and sets it up for you. It picks the right build (64-bit or ARM) for your machine.
- Need an older version for a library? `py install 3.14`.

04 Mac and Linux

▶ VIDEO 02:18

- **Mac:** download the macOS installer, click Continue, Agree, Install. Then open **Applications › Python 3.15** and double-click **Install Certificates**. On a Mac the command is `python3`.
- **Linux:** Python comes preinstalled on most distributions. Type `python3` to check.

05 Check It Works

▶ VIDEO 02:49

Terminal

```
> python --version
Python 3.15.2
> python
>>> 2 + 2
4
>>> exit
```

KEY IDEA

The three arrows `>>>` are the Python prompt: the interpreter is waiting for you. On a Mac or Linux, use `python3` instead of `python`.

06 Troubleshooting

▶ VIDEO 03:23

If typing `python` opens the **Microsoft Store**, the install manager usually isn't installed yet: install it first. Already installed? Search the Start menu for **Manage app execution aliases** and switch the Python entries on.

CODE 1 file on GitHub github.com/abitclearer/python-and-ai/tree/main/03-how-to-install-python